

BOLD BLITZ
Tejaswi Yadav in Muzaffarpur, Bihar, in Feb. 20

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BIHAR

GAME ON FOR TEJASWI

it did—and why. He mandated that even the unsuccessful Lok Sabha contestants undertake an *aabhaar yatra* (gratitude tour) across every assembly segment of their constituencies. Concurrently, Tejaswi is gearing up for an extensive tour of the state, set to begin in August.

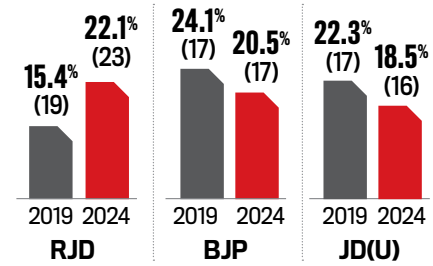
If Tejaswi appears proactive, the NDA partners are equally prepared to present a united front. On June 6, after a meeting of the BJP's election management committee in Patna, deputy chief minister Samrat Choudhary reaffirmed his party's support for Nitish's leadership: "We've been fighting elections under Nitish Kumar since 1996 and will continue to do so. What's the issue in having Nitish as leader?"

Encouraged by a rise in LS polls vote share, the RJD is planning an early start for the upcoming assembly polls

This acquiescence may not only be due to Nitish's indispensability for the BJP, given his 12 Lok Sabha MPs, but also because the Opposition, under the INDIA bloc led by Tejaswi in Bihar, is at its strongest. "The BJP has realised it is not the time to go it alone in Bihar. We are yet to become *aatmanirbhar* (self-reliant)," says a party leader. While Nitish has solidified his status as the second most important BJP ally at the Centre, a closer look at the Lok Sabha election results reveals a narrative that seems to hold more promise for the RJD. Its accumulation of a sizeable vote share is concomitant with the marginal decline experienced by the BJP and the Janata Dal (United). The BJP's vote share dropped from 23.6 per cent in 2019 to 20.52 per cent in 2024, while the JD(U)'s share decreased from 21.8 per cent to 18.52 per cent—even if it won both of them 12 seats each. Conversely, the RJD's vote share leapt from 15.4 per cent in 2019 to 22.1 per cent now—the highest individual party score. More than the four seats it gained (from none in 2019), the vote share augmentation matches almost exactly the combined decline of the BJP and JD(U), speaking of a transfer of voter affections.

THE RJD SURGE

The party's vote share this LS election has seen a 52%* rise over 2019



Of total 40, seats contested in ( ); *RJD contested 4 more seats than in 2019

How that has come about is equally noteworthy. The RJD's growth is not solely attributable to its traditional Muslim-Yadav vote bank. The party appears to have attracted a significant portion of the Kushwaha voters, who comprise 4.2 per cent of Bihar's population. The RJD-led Opposition fielded seven Kushwaha candidates; the JD(U) two, the BJP none. Among the Opposition candidates, though only two Kushwaha leaders won compared to the JD(U)'s one, the results suggest the RJD has successfully disrupted Nitish's 'Luv-Kush' (Kurmi-Kushwaha) constituency.

Tejaswi's crossover appeal was already evident in the 2020 assembly polls when he pretty much had a baptism by fire as a solo leader, leading the RJD against the JD(U)-BJP alliance and emerging the single-largest party with 75 seats and a 23.1 per cent vote share. His employment-centric campaign that year secured nearly 39 per cent of the votes in the 144 seats the RJD contested, far surpassing the traditional 32 per cent vote